

near cities planted more specialized crops for sale in regional markets. Farmers in New England and the states of the Mid-Atlantic seaboard used cash from these market sales to buy improved equipment, which reduced their labor costs and increased their yields. Steel cutting blades, threshers, iron plows, and horse-drawn rakes enabled one farmer to do the work that formerly needed six men. In the Northeast, the growing populations in mill towns and urban centers required increasing quantities of meat, corn, wheat, wool, fruit, vegetables, and dairy produce.

There was a steady drift of people to the expanding cities. Seven out of eight immigrants before 1860 settled in cities such as New York, Boston, Philadelphia, Pittsburgh, Chicago, and Rochester—all north of the Mason-Dixon Line. This historic geographic line was surveyed in the 1760s by the astronomer Charles Mason and the surveyor Jeremiah Dixon to resolve a border dispute between Pennsylvania and Maryland.

31,443,321 **The U.S. population in 1860. This represented an increase of over 35 percent in the 10 years since 1850, and over 270 percent since 1815, when the population stood at 8.4 million.**

Industry takes off

Between 1815 and 1860, the people of the United States transformed the economy. Following his development of the cotton gin, Eli Whitney devised a system of interchangeable parts for weapons manufacture that was soon used to make other goods, such as sewing machines and farm equipment. This simplification of the manufacturing process, known as the “American system,” greatly reduced costs. New Englanders pioneered the first large, water-powered factories, employing local women to produce cotton textiles.

By the 1830s, U.S. industry had gained momentum. In 1807, there were fewer than 20 cotton mills with around 8,000 spindles for making thread; by 1831, a greater number of mills had nearly 1.2 million spindles. Steam engines transformed mining and iron production, powered mills and workshops, and moved goods by rail and water. Factories replaced craftsmen and household production